Nobulous Apprenticeship Program (NAP)

A prestigious opportunity. Terms and conditions apply.

One Apprentice, three Time Slots a day, and a workload that does not care how tired you are. Earn Credits across four subjects, survive the things that go wrong, and pass a Final Exam assembled from the subjects you actually studied.

COMPONENTS

- 3 double-sided Apprentice cards — 6 Apprentices, one to a side
- 26 Task cards
- 6 Opportunity cards
- 6 Setback cards — Tasks, Opportunities and your difficulty's Setbacks make up the **Assignment deck**
- 3 Time Slot cards — Morning, Afternoon, Evening
- 3 FINF cards, numbered **1 Morning**, **2 Afternoon** and **3 Evening**. They carry the Assignment back, so Increase can hide them in the deck
- 12 Final Exam cards
- **From 20 Strong:** the 17 unit dice — 4 Purple, 4 Blue, 4 Green, 4 Yellow, 1 Red
- **From 20 Strong:** the 3 stat dice — Health, Strategy and Recovery, which hold your Apprentice's HP, STR and REC — and the Chip, which is the dial that carries Special Recovery from one Time Slot to the next.

SETUP

1. Choose an Apprentice. All six begin at **2 HP / 2 STR / 2 REC**; they differ only in abilities.
2. Choose a difficulty: **Easy 5**, **Standard 6**, **Hard 7** or **Nobulous 8** Credits.
3. Shuffle in **your difficulty's Setbacks** — 3, 3, 4 or 5 of the 6, from the *Difficulty* table below — with the 26 Tasks and 6 Opportunities to form the Assignment deck. Return the unused Setbacks to the box.
4. Choose a FINF setting: **Increase 1–3** or **Reduce 1–3**. Standard is **Reduce 1**. Take that many of the 3 FINF cards at random; return the rest to the box. See *Following in Nobulous' Footsteps* below for what each direction does.
5. Separate the 12 Final Exams. You will build the exam pool later.
6. Take all 17 dice as available.
7. Place the Morning Time Slot card as active for Day 1.

OBJECT OF THE GAME

The Final Exam comes either way. You sit it when you reach your **Credit goal** — 6 Credits at Standard difficulty — or when the Assignment deck runs out, whichever happens first; arriving short of the goal does not end the game, it costs you dice (see *Leaving the apprenticeship*). Then survive three exams with at least 1 Health remaining. Credits are earned by completing Credit Tasks and are never spent — completed Tasks remain visible in their Time Slot until End of Day, then enter the face-up discard pile as the record of that subject.

FOLLOWING IN NOBULOUS' FOOTSTEPS (FINF)

FINF is a second dial, independent of the difficulty level, and it works in two directions. The three FINF cards are numbered **1 Morning**, **2 Afternoon** and **3 Evening**. Choose one setting before you start and keep it for the whole game.

Increase — 1 / 2 / 3

Take that many FINF cards at random and **shuffle them into the Assignment deck**. They share the Assignment back, so they are hidden until drawn. When one is drawn, place it before the Primary selection for that slot and **add an Assignment from the top of the deck to the Time Slot the card is numbered for** — the Time Slot you are in, or another one — then discard the FINF card. Ignore Skulls on Assignments added by FINF, and never exceed 4 Assignments in one row.

Reduce — 1 / 2 / 3

Take that many FINF cards at random and **flip them aside, face-up**. Each is one use. You may **remove a non-Final-Exam card from the active Time Slot** only if you hold the FINF card numbered for that slot: spend it, exhaust every die stored on the removed card, and turn the FINF card face-down. Holding FINF 2, for example, lets you remove one card during an Afternoon.

FINF is not used during the Final Exam, in either direction.

DIFFICULTY

Difficulty is two numbers: the **Credit goal** you must reach before the Final Exam, and how many of the **6 Setbacks** are shuffled into the Assignment deck. Choose a level before you start and keep it for the whole game.

LEVEL	CREDIT GOAL	SETBACKS
Easy	5 Credits	3
Standard	**6 Credits**	**3**
Hard	7 Credits	4
Nobulous	8 Credits	5

The Credit goal cannot carry the dial alone: Credits also reduce Final Exam Targets, so asking for more hands some of it back, and past 8 there are not enough Assignments left to earn them. The deck is the other half. The FINF dial is separate again and can be set at any difficulty.

SUBJECT ICONS

Task and Final Exam cards use these icons to identify their subject. A Task with no subject icon is unmarked.

ICON	SUBJECT
	Anatomy
	Engineering
	Procedure
	Theory

HOW THE APPRENTICESHIP ENDS

Play Days until **either** you reach your Credit goal **or** the Assignment deck runs out. Both send you to the Final Exam; arriving short of the goal just costs you dice (see *Leaving the apprenticeship*).

The exam begins at the end of a Day, never part-way through one. Reaching your Credit goal does not interrupt the Day: play out the Time Slots that are left, resolve End of Day, and then sit the exam. A goal reached in a Morning therefore still leaves you an Afternoon and an Evening. They are worth having — each Credit above your goal recovers another die in *Preparation* — and worth watching, because an Assignment on its Demand side bills you again at the end of every slot it survives. It is also why Preparation performs the queued *Morning* recovery: the exam sits where the next Morning would have been.

Running out of Assignments is the exception and ends the apprenticeship where it happens, because with no deck there is nothing to reveal and the remaining Time Slots cannot be played.

If your Health ever reaches 0 you lose immediately — during the apprenticeship or during the exams.

THE DAY

Each day has three Time Slots: **Morning**, **Afternoon**, **Evening**. Each slot runs:

1. Perform **Special Recovery** for the color on the dial — the one the last Primary queued. **This is the slot's only recovery.** (Day 1 Morning has nothing queued, so there is none.)
2. Reveal 2 Assignments and take one into the row as your **Primary**. **Discard the other Assignment.** A Setback among the two **must** be the one you take. The Primary's recovery-color dot sets the color queued for the next Time Slot.
3. Work Assignments with Strategy rolls.
4. Rotate or discard unresolved Assignments as described below and exhaust non-stored committed dice. Then set the dial to the Primary's dot and advance. **Do not recover again** — the dial you have just set is what the next slot recovers on, at its step 1.

After Evening, resolve End of Day.

The row is **the same row all game**: Assignments you do not clear stay on the table and follow you into the next Time Slot. A slot holds a maximum of **4** Assignments — if the row is already full when you reveal, discard both revealed cards and take nothing. **The queued recovery color does not change** when that happens: with no Primary to set a new one, the dial stays where it is and the next Time Slot recovers on the same color again.

SPECIAL RECOVERY

Recover **all** exhausted dice of the queued recovery color. Then recover dice equal to your REC separately.

STR in NAP

STR is the number of **Strategy rolls** available in the Time Slot, and it resets every slot. That is all it governs. **It does not cap how many Assignments you may complete.** One roll's successes can be spread across several Assignments, and cards already holding stored progress can finish alongside them, so clearing more Assignments than you have Strategy rolls is normal — it is what storing progress is *for*.

WORKING ASSIGNMENTS

- You may spread dice across as many Assignments as you like during a roll.
- **Required Effort.** Every roll must be a real attempt: choose at least one Assignment — a Setback if one is present — and commit either one die matching that Assignment's color dot, Red, or at least two dice of another color. Empty rolls are illegal. **Waive this only if no legal commitment is possible at all.**
- To **complete an Assignment or store progress on it**, the successes you apply must include a successful die matching its color dot, Red as wild, or two successful dice of the same other color. The color rule governs storing as well as finishing — you cannot bank progress with dice that could never have counted.

Unresolved Assignments

- Successful dice on an unresolved Assignment may be **stored as progress** instead of exhausted.
- **At the end of the Time Slot**, every unresolved Task or Setback flips to its **Demand** side — a harsher printed effect, and often a higher Target. Flipping costs nothing by itself.
- An unresolved Opportunity rotates **180 degrees** for one final chance in the next Time Slot. Opportunities store no progress. If the rotated Opportunity is still incomplete at the end of that slot, discard it without applying an effect or penalty.
- An Assignment that is *already* on its Demand side and still unresolved at the end of a slot **inflicts its printed Demand penalty**, and does so again at the end of every slot it survives. When a penalty exhausts dice, exhaust dice of that Assignment's **recovery-dot color** first; if you hold none, exhaust your weakest.
- Once the next Time Slot begins, stored dice are locked to that Assignment and cannot be voluntarily exhausted.

- When an Assignment finally resolves, its committed and stored dice exhaust unless the card says otherwise. A Credit Task completed on its **Demand** side still earns its Credit.
- Rotate every completed Task, Opportunity, or Setback **90 degrees clockwise** and leave it in its Time Slot until End of Day. Resolve its completion reward before continuing. Completed cards no longer count toward the limit of 4 unresolved Assignments in that row.
- Completing an Opportunity never pays out on the spot: you **keep the card as a coupon** (see *Coupons*).

Assignment types

TYPE	ROLE
Task	The only source of Credits.
Setback	Mandatory and disruptive. No Credits.
Opportunity	Optional. No Credits or penalties; rotate once for a final chance. Completing one earns a coupon.

Coupons

An Opportunity pays nothing when you complete it. Instead you **keep the card in front of you as a coupon**. A coupon has no expiry: spend it whenever you like, on any Day, including during the Final Exam. Each is **one use** — spend it, apply the effect, then discard the card.

OPPORTUNITY	SPEND IT TO…
Take an Unauthorized Break	Cancel 1 Health loss.
Raid the Supply Closet	Count one die as any color for one roll.
Borrow Better Instruments	Add 1 success to a roll.
Study Nobulous' Notes	Reduce one Assignment's remaining need by 2.
Salvage Useful Components	Add 2 successes to an Assignment, without rolling.
Practice on a Spare Brain	Count one Crit as 3 successes.

Coupons that add successes still obey the color rule: they add to an application that already includes a legal die. You may hold any number of coupons, and unspent coupons score nothing at the end of the game.

> **SKULLS**
>
> Skulls resolve only on Assignments *you chose*. Ignore Skulls on cards added by another Skull, by FINF, or by a forced replacement. If a Skull would add an Assignment while the slot already holds 4, do not add a card — instead rotate the Skull-generating Assignment to its Demand side once. Further blocked Skulls do nothing.

END OF DAY

Move all completed Assignments from the Time Slots to the face-up discard pile. Reveal and discard the top card of the Assignment deck. Ignore all of its text, effects and Skulls.

THE FINAL EXAM

Leaving the apprenticeship

Discard unresolved Assignments and exhaust their stored dice. If you are short of your Credit goal, exhaust 1 available die per missing Credit in the order Red, Purple, Blue, Green, Yellow, looping as needed.

Preparation

- Recover 1 exhausted die.
- Recover 1 further exhausted die per Credit *above* your Credit goal. Excess-Credit recovery may not pick the same color twice.
- Perform the queued Morning recovery.

Building the exam pool

For each subject independently, place cards from that subject into the pool:

CREDITS IN SUBJECT	CARDS PLACED
0–1	1
2–3	2
4+	3

Shuffle the pool and draw **3** Final Exams.

Resolving the exams

1. Reduce the exam's base Target by 1 for each Credit you hold in that subject.
2. Roll against the modified Target, honoring the exam's printed restriction.
3. **Lose 1 Health for each success below the modified Target.** If you still have Health, you passed.
4. Perform Special Recovery using that exam card's own color dot, then resolve the next exam.

All three exams are mandatory. FINF is not used during the Final Exam. Finish all three with at least 1 Health to win NAP.

CARRYING NAP FORWARD

Only relevant if you are playing the Nobulous Research Journal (NRJ) campaign, which is Tier III only.

NAP contributes its **6 Devious Opportunities**, and nothing leaves the Final Exam deck. One you completed is **retained**, up to 3 — whether you then spent it makes no difference; one you never completed is a **candidate**. A retained card reduces a **Knowledge** Exhibit's Target by **2**. NAP carries three where the others carry two, because completing one already costs a Credit Task.